

the fence on the restoration of the judiciary.

When Zardari dithered, Sharif pulled his ministers out of the Cabinet stating they would not return till the judges were reinstated. With Governance seriously impaired and the economy going into a tailspin, Zardari sensed that the PPP would become the prime target of public disillusionment. Worse, Musharraf had begun threatening his own political space by hobnobbing with dissident elements in the PPP and sharply criticising the Government's performance in meeting with allies. Zardari knew that it was imperative he got rid of Musharraf. That realisation coincided with the army brass complaining that Musharraf's shadow still loomed large over the forces. Army chief General Ashfaq Kayani indicated that his force had stood by Musharraf long enough and to restore the army's credibility it would stay out of politics. America too acknowledged that Musharraf had become a liability and was not averse to his removal.



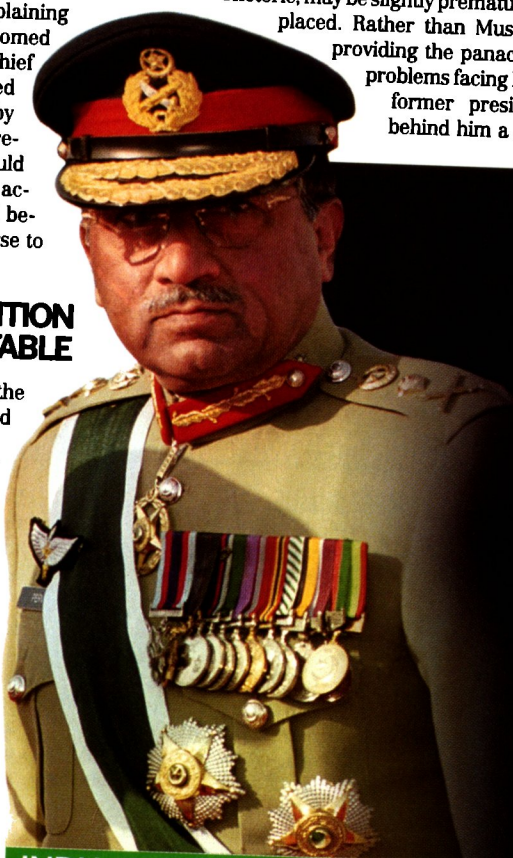
WHY THE COALITION REMAINS UNSTABLE

Having secured the backing of the army and the US, Zardari decided to strike out against Musharraf. On August 5 when he met Sharif in Islamabad, he surprised him by proposing that they oust Musharraf first and then restore the judges. According to Sharif, Zardari told him that "the President could be an impediment to the reinstatement of the judges, so let him be out of the way first". Sharif agreed but got an agreement duly signed by Zardari stating that the judges would be reinstated "immediately after" Musharraf was sent packing. That was when they decided on the move to impeach him after issuing a chargesheet.

Had Musharraf not resigned, he would almost surely have been turfed out by the coalition Government that had managed to gather on its side more than the two-thirds of the members of the National Assembly and Senate needed to impeach the President. But nobody—least of all, the powerful army—relished the prospect of a long, drawn-out and acrimonious public spectacle of an impeachment process that would have

led to further political and economic uncertainty in the country. A former army chief being dragged through the mud was also a precedent the military was not in favour of setting. In the end, it seems certain guarantees provided by Musharraf's longtime allies—the army, the US, Britain and Saudi Arabia—persuaded the former strongman to call it a day, Pakistan's first military leader to have been allowed to leave with some shreds of his dignity still intact.

But the outpouring of elation from the anti-Musharraf politicians and the public, swept up in rhetoric, may be slightly premature, if not misplaced. Rather than Musharraf's exit providing the panacea to all the problems facing Pakistan, the former president leaves behind him a country fac-



MAN of MANY faces

Pervez Musharraf has left a mixed legacy of his almost nine years in power in Pakistan. A look at some of the critical phases of his time at the helm...

INDIA NOW FEELS PAKISTAN HAS GONE BACK TO ITS

ing some of the stiffest challenges of its history—a coalition government that is already fracturing over issues that require bitter pills to be swallowed and a minimum of national consensus. If anything, Musharraf's departure has brought into sharp focus the real faultlines of Pakistan's politics.

Part of the problem has been that everyone understands that real power, and decision-mak-